

Safe to Skip Radiotherapy With Negative PET in Hodgkin Lymphoma

Nancy A. Melville

June 15, 2020

([ADD TO EMAIL ALERTS](#))

In early stage unfavorable Hodgkin lymphoma respond well enough to a current standard regimen of 4 cycles of chemotherapy, and can skip the additional radiotherapy that is normally included in the combined modality treatment, say experts reporting the final results from an international phase 3 randomized trial dubbed HD17.

"Most patients with this disease will not need radiotherapy any longer," concluded first author Peter Borchmann, MD, assistant medical director in the Department of Hematology/Oncology at the University Hospital of Cologne, Germany.

Borchmann was speaking online as part of the virtual edition of the European Hematology Association (EHA) 25th Annual Congress 2020.

"Importantly, the mortality of patients with early stage unfavorable Hodgkin lymphoma in the HD17 study did not differ from the normal healthy German population, and this is the first time we have had this finding in one of our studies," he emphasized.

Borchmann added that positron emission tomography (PET) imaging is key in deciding which patients can skip radiation.

"We conclude from the HD17 trial that the combined modality concept can and should be replaced by a PET-guided omission of radiotherapy for patients with newly diagnosed early stage unfavorable Hodgkin lymphoma," he said.

"The vast majority of early stage unfavorable Hodgkin lymphoma patients can be treated with the brief and highly effective 2+2 chemotherapy alone," he added.

Therefore, he continued, "PET-guided 2+2 chemotherapy is the new standard of care for the German Hodgkin study group," which conducted the trial.

The use of both chemotherapy and radiation has long been a standard approach to treatment, and this combined modality treatment is highly effective, Borchmann explained. But it can cause long-term damage, and the known longer-term negative effects of radiotherapy, such as cardiovascular disease and second malignancies, are a particular concern because patients with early stage Hodgkin lymphoma are relatively young, with a median age of around 30 years at disease onset.

An expert approached for comment said that the momentum to skip radiotherapy when possible is an ongoing issue, and importantly, this study adds to those efforts.

"The treatment of Hodgkin lymphoma has moved for many years now to less radiation therapy, and this trend will continue with the results of this study," commented John G. Gribben, MD, director of the Stem Cell Transplantation Program and medical director of the North East London Cancer Research Network Centre at Barts Cancer Center of Excellence and The London School of Medicine, UK.

"We have moved to lower doses and involved fields with the intent of decreasing toxicity, and particularly long-term toxicity from radiotherapy," he told *Medscape Medical News*.